



KANSAS EMPLOYMENT FIRST PROJECT

Recommendation Prioritization Working Group for Employment First Implementation

Summary Report

To support the implementation of the Kansas Employment First law, the Institute for Community Inclusion at UMass Boston (ICI) organized and facilitated a series of working meetings in the spring of 2025. The ICI leads policy analysis for the Kansas Employment First project.

The purpose of these meetings was to identify and prioritize action steps for state agencies to take to improve employment outcomes for people with disabilities. Members of the Kansas Employment First Steering Committee volunteered or were nominated to join the group and identify their highest system change priorities.

ICI uses the Higher Performing States Framework (see Figure 1) to guide systems change to expand integrated employment in its work across the United States. This type of holistic approach can help Kansas realize a vision of Employment First and increase employment for individuals with intellectual and/or developmental disabilities (I/DD).

Figure 1: Higher Performing States Framework for Integrated Employment

Higher Performing Framework

Essential Elements



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The working group met online three times between April and May 2025. It included 11 members representing a wide variety of key stakeholders, including state agencies, provider organizations, disability rights advocates, and self-advocacy organizations. To prepare for the meetings, members reviewed a draft report developed by ICI about the long-time barriers to Employment First in Kansas. They also reviewed a list of recommendations to address these barriers. Prior to each meeting, working group members ranked their priority recommendations. During the meetings, members discussed the recommendations both as a whole group and in smaller breakout rooms. They worked toward building consensus on the most critical recommendations from the report. The discussions considered ongoing policy implementation efforts, the necessary sequence of actions, and feasibility of the recommendations.

The working group prioritized a series of recommendations presented within relevant elements of the Higher Performing Framework. ICI staff advise structuring the implementation of the recommendations in the following order:

STEP 1:

Leadership: Establish a collaborative operational leadership team to support implementation and monitoring of Kansas' employment goals at the regional and local levels, September 2025

Action Steps:

- » The Disability Employment Subcabinet Group (DESG) and the Kansas Department of Aging and Disability Services (KDADS) should establish the collaborative operational Employment Leadership Team for the purpose of supporting the implementation and monitoring of Kansas' employment goals at the programmatic, regional, and local levels. DESG and KDADS should at a minimum consider the following state agencies for membership: KDADS, Department of Education, Kansas Rehabilitation Services, Department of Commerce, and Kansas Department of Health and Environment (KDHE).
- » DESG and KDADS should identify dedicated and consistent staff within their state agencies and as appropriate within agency departments and divisions who will comprise the Employment Leadership Team. These staff will support the coordination and implementation of state and agency level strategic employment objectives.
- » The Employment Leadership Team should propose strategic goals at the state and operating agency level for the next five years. These goals should be shared with the DESG and KDADS for approval and to ensure that efforts align across and within state agencies to promote consistent and coordinated progress.
- » DESG, KDADS, and the Employment Leadership Team should collaboratively establish methods of coordination between the three entities, as well as administrative processes for the Employment Leadership Team, including, but not limited to: who will convene the team, how information will be shared between the state level groups and team members, and frequency of communication.

STEP 2 (A-C):

Develop and implement a series a of short-term, ad hoc groups that report to the Employment Leadership Team and will address issues related to a) service planning and coordination, b) funding for employment and other services that support employment, and c) capacity building.

2.a. Ad Hoc Group on Service Planning, October–December 2025

Action Steps:

- » The Employment Leadership Team members should identify within their state agencies where the functions of case management and employment planning activities occur for people with disabilities. Members should then appoint staff from their respective agencies to form a 3-month interagency working group. The Employment Leadership Team will include members from Self-Advocate Coalition of Kansas (SACK) and a parent group such as Families Together. The working group will report twice per month to the Employment Leadership Team.
- » The Employment Leadership Team will charge the ad hoc group to identify needed revisions to existing service planning documents and processes so that employment is the priority outcome, with a focus on employment service planning across the lifespan.
- » The ad hoc group should also draft service planning processes that encompass multiple state, regional, and local entities so that individuals are able to access all the potential services that could support their employment outcome.
- » Examples of areas already identified for the ad hoc group to address include:
 - Strengthen the focus on employment during service and person-centered planning conversations, particularly at younger ages, and at all key transition points, including within schools, during adult service planning, and through Pre-Employment Transition Services (Pre-ETS).
 - Develop a standardized pathway tool for coordination and planning, and to help individuals and families navigate services and employment opportunities.
 - Embed and document employment conversations as part of the person-centered service plan.
 - Develop a process to ensure that benefits planning and counseling are part of the service planning process to improve informed choice, access, and coordination of employment and other life supports.
 - Review and make recommendations related to training about employment for personnel who manage person-centered service planning, including those contracted through Community Developmental Disability Organizations (CDDOs) and Managed Care Organizations (MCOs).
 - Adjust intake processes and policies to ensure accountability for employment services and outcomes.
 - » Clarify the role of CDDOs and MCOs in presenting service options that emphasize employment. Provide guidance for ensuring these conversations are thorough and consistently implemented.
 - » Establish guidance and protocols for quality assurance assessors.

2.b. Ad Hoc Group on Funding for Employment, October–December 2025

Action Steps:

- » The Employment Leadership Team members should identify within their state agencies where service definitions, rate setting, and funding structure implementation occur for people with disabilities. Members should then appoint staff from their respective agencies to form a 3-month interagency working group. The Employment Leadership Team should also consider including members from Interhab, community rehabilitation providers, Disability Rights Center of Kansas (DRC), University of Kansas (KU), SACK, and family groups. The working group will report twice per month to the Employment Leadership Team.
- » The Employment Leadership Team will charge the ad hoc group to identify and develop materials to support the implementation of new funding structures for employment and related services so that employment is the priority at the individual and provider levels.
- » Examples of areas already identified for the ad hoc group to address include:
 - Align funding recommendations with the work currently underway in partnership with Public Consulting Group (PCG) to ensure consistency. Include clarifying billable activities, particularly direct vs indirect services and supports that support providers in delivering services effectively.
 - Identify whether existing funding structures within each agency support funding to access technology that supports employment, including funding for tools and devices that support people in obtaining and maintaining competitive integrated employment. If yes, identify processes to ensure these are widely available and included in the work for the Ad Hoc Group on Person Centered Planning. If no, identify ways other states meet this need.
 - Support providers to implement sustainable business models for employment services.
 - » Develop a financial modeling system to support providers in assessing the implementation of proposed rates.
 - » Develop technical support and resources around funding mechanisms for providers.
- » Identify data that is still needed to support long-term refinement of appropriate reimbursement rates based upon varying levels of support, especially for ongoing employment supports to ensure provider sustainability.

2.c. Ad Hoc Group on Capacity Building, January–March 2026

Action Steps:

- » The Employment Leadership Team members should identify within their state agencies where the functions of training and technical assistance to individuals, families, providers, state agency staff, educators, CDDOs, and MCOs occur related to supporting employment for people with disabilities. Employment Leadership Team members should then appoint staff from their respective agencies to form a 3-month interagency working group. The Employment Leadership Team should also consider including members from Interhab, community rehabilitation providers, DRC, KU, SACK, and Parent Training Organizations (PTOs). The working group will report to the Employment Leadership Team.

- » The Employment Leadership Team will charge the ad hoc group to identify existing opportunities to embed training and technical assistance on employment for these groups. The team could also consider whether an annual statewide Employment First Conference is appropriate.
- » Examples of areas already identified for the ad hoc group to address include:
 - Increase engagement and technical assistance with providers to ensure effective implementation and collaboration throughout the system.
 - Increase the number of certified benefits planners as well as access to basic online benefits information, including contracting with DB101 to create a module for Kansas that can be used by individuals, families, case managers, providers, educators, and others.

The ad hoc groups will seek feedback from key stakeholders on all recommendations as they are developed.

Spring 2025 Working Group Members

Name	Title	Organization
Amanda Ramsey	Special Projects Manager, CPWIC	Kansas Commerce
Colin Olenick	Self-Advocate	Self-Advocate Coalition of Kansas (SACK)
Liz Long	Director, Working Healthy (Work and STEPs programs)	KDHE
Mark Dietzler	Workforce Employment First Specialist	KDADS
Martha Gabehart	Executive Director	Kansas Commission on Disability Concerns (KCDC)
Mike Burgess	Director of Policy and Outreach	Disability Rights Center
Mitzie Tyree	Director of HCBS Initiatives	KDADS
Phil Bentzinger	Director, CESP	Job Link
Rocky Nichols	Executive Director	Disability Rights Center
Seth Kilber	Assistant Commissioner	KDADS
Shelia Nelson-Stout	Chief Executive Officer	OCCK



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ThinkWork! is the Institute for Community Inclusion's (ICI) resource hub offering data, personal stories, innovative practices, and tools related to improving employment outcomes for people with intellectual and developmental disabilities (IDD). ThinkWork is a collaborator on the Kansas Employment First initiative.

www.ThinkWork.org